



ON THE MOVE: EVMs being transported in Assam

officials say the number of electronic checks and balances are far too many, making the machine virtually tamper-proof. The machine has a date and time stamp for each vote and accepts a vote every 12 seconds. Even this exactitude would arouse suspicion because it usually takes a voter around four minutes to walk in, have his name identified and finally use the machine. In the words of a former election commissioner, it would take the complicity of over 1,000 people to successfully rig the EVMs. "EVMs wave an important flag of democracy and have become an integral and foolproof part of our electoral process," says Election Commissioner Navin Chawla.

It is a flag so simple and user-friendly that it baffles even a technological giant like the United States which saw Al Gore losing a dubious election to George Bush in 2000. The Indian EVM, manufactured by defence public sector unit Bharat Electronic Ltd, and the Electronics Corporation of India Ltd, is a sleek briefcase-sized carrying case. Inside is a machine so simple that it resembles a child's electronic synthesiser rather than a swank polling gadget. It consists of two parts, a control unit held by an electoral officer and a voting unit, both connected with a five-metre cable and powered by internal six-volt batteries. Punching in a party symbol gives a loud beep. The vote has been cast. At the heart of the gadget is a thumbnail-sized microchip which stores all the polling data, which can either be erased or stored up to five years. Each EVM can hold up to 3,840 votes and each machine used to vote for a maximum of 20 candidates. More contenders mean a second machine holding another 20 candidates.

The unit cost of Rs 10,000 per piece sounds steep but is easily recovered by the physical labour it saves, not to mention the forests the paperless process has helped preserve. The EVM boasts a failure rate of less than 0.5 per cent and even this, EC officials say, has been attributable to human error. Newer variants set to debut in the forthcoming state polls feature a number with a Braille strip on the side for the visually-handicapped. When they are not in use, the machines are sealed and stored in each district, under double-lock and armed guards. A powerful symbol of the Indian electoral process, waiting to be awakened on polling day. ■

C. RAJADURAI, election official during the Kashmir elections, 1999

"These machines have made life so much more easier for us as well as the voters."

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